

PERCH AND RELATIVES

With at least 162 families and over 11,500 species, the Perciformes form the largest and most diverse vertebrate order. Most have both spines and soft rays in their dorsal and anal fins. The pelvic fins are set well forward, close to the pectoral fins. New research means that some families included here are likely to be moved into existing or new orders.



LONGFIN SPADEFISH

Platax teira
F: Ehippidae

Living on coral reefs in the Indo-Pacific, this flattened species patrols in small groups, feeding on algae and invertebrates.

60 cm
23½ in



FOURSPOT BUTTERFLYFISH

Chaetodon quadrimaculatus
F: Chaetodontidae

Many different species of butterflyfish are found on coral reefs around the world. This fish lives in the W. Pacific.

16 cm
6½ in

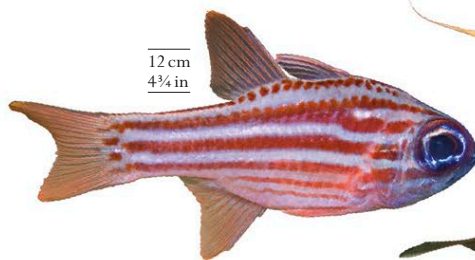


BLUE-SPOTTED SEABREAM

Pagrus caeruleostictus
F: Sparidae

Found in the E. Atlantic, this is a typical seabream with a steep head profile, forked tail, and long dorsal fin.

90 cm
35 in



OCHRE-STRIPED CARDINALFISH

Ostorhinchus compressus
F: Apogonidae

This coral-reef resident of the W. Pacific is a small, nocturnal species with two dorsal fins and large eyes. The male incubates the eggs in his mouth.

12 cm
4¾ in



RED BANDFISH

Cepola macrophthalma
F: Cepolidae

Living in vertical mud burrows in the N.E. Atlantic, the red bandfish feeds on passing plankton.

80 cm
32 in



RED MULLET

Mullus surmuletus
F: Mullidae

Common in the Mediterranean and N.E. Atlantic, this species detects buried prey with its mobile barbels. It is a relative of the tropical goatfish.

40 cm
16 in



GREEN SUNFISH

Lepomis cyanellus
F: Centrarchidae

Well known in N. America, this large species is one of the most common fish in lakes and rivers.

31 cm
12 in



BANDED ARCHERFISH

Toxotes jaculator
F: Toxotidae

Living mainly in brackish mangrove estuaries in S.E. Asia, Australia, and the W. Pacific, this fish catches insects from overhanging branches by shooting a jet of water from its mouth.

30 cm
12 in



HARLEQUIN SWEETLIPS

Plectorhinchus chaetodonoides
F: Haemulidae

The adult harlequin sweetlips is cream with black spots. The colour and movement of the juvenile shown here mimics a toxic flatworm.

72 cm
28 in

juvenile has brown
body with black-edged
white spots



BLUEFISH

Pomatomus saltatrix
F: Pomatomidae

This widespread, voracious, and aggressive predator roams tropical and subtropical oceans in schools that herd and attack smaller fish.

1.2 m
4 ft



YELLOWHEAD JAWFISH

Opistognathus aurifrons
F: Opistognathidae

After the female of this Caribbean fish has laid her eggs, the male broods them in his mouth.

10 cm
4 in



EUROPEAN PERCH

Perca fluviatilis
F: Percidae

Native to Europe and Asia, this widespread, predatory freshwater fish has been introduced as a sport fish for anglers in Australia and elsewhere, where it has become a pest.

51 cm
20 in